

Chapter 177-15

After a long while, Zhu Mingqi suddenly burst into sorrowful tears: "How did we... end up like this?"

Actually, the beginning of the story was quite simple.

Shen Chi, as an emotional painter, was beautiful and also a smooth-talking Alpha, so naturally many people liked her.

Qiu Zimin and Zhu Mingqi were close friends first. Later, through Zhu Mingqi, Qiu Zimin got to know Shen Chi.

The Zhu family and the Shen family were old family friends, so Shen Chi and Zhu Mingqi's relationship was closer.

Zhu Mingqi was using Shen Chi to get close to Shen Yaobo.

But Shen Chi liked Zhu Mingqi.

And Qiu Zimin liked Shen Chi, to the point of infatuation.

The two had even dated briefly, but Shen Chi said they weren't compatible.

She thought Qiu Zimin had let go, but in reality, Qiu Zimin was only watching her flirt with Zhu Mingqi, growing more and more jealous.

The friendship among the three gradually fractured and died amid these emotions, though on the surface everything still appeared smooth.

Neither Zhu Mingqi nor Shen Chi knew what Qiu Zimin was thinking.

Until Shen Chi was diagnosed with a serious illness and disappeared abroad without telling anyone.

Only then did Qiu Zimin explode at Zhu Mingqi, demanding to know why.

Then their relationship broke down, and they were no longer sisters.

Zhu Mingqi later fell in love with Shen Yaobo and married him.

Qiu Zimin also married Liang Zu under her family's persuasion, and life was fairly smooth at first.

But then she heard that Zhu Mingqi had given birth to a third daughter, while her own daughter had been stolen.

After giving birth to two sons in a row, Qiu Zimin desperately wanted a daughter. She felt a daughter might have Shen Chi's shadow in her.

But unexpectedly, her daughter was stolen.

She happened to see Yang Gui's embarrassing situation of borrowing money everywhere, and so this idea came to her.

At first, she wanted to strangle Zhu Mingqi's daughter—after all, it looked like she wouldn't live much longer anyway.

But she thought it would be even better to raise Zhu Mingqi's daughter into a failure, and then she could take revenge on Zhu Mingqi.

And so, a plan that would lie dormant for over twenty years was born.

However, things didn't go as she wished—Liang Shi still didn't turn out badly.

After Zhu Mingqi and the others left the ward, Qiu Zimin sat there motionlessly.

After a while, she suddenly spat a mouthful of blood directly onto the hospital bed—her fury had attacked her heart¹.

That same day, she fell into a coma.

In less than three days, she passed away.

Before she died, she said to Liang Xinzhou: "Take care of your younger brother and sister."

She thought, she was going to find Shen Chi now.

Qiu Zimin's death caught everyone off guard.

Zhu Mingqi even fell into self-blame over it, wondering if she had gone too far by going to the hospital to settle accounts with her that day.

But thinking about it later, anyone who learned about those things wouldn't have been able to hold back.

She had done the right thing.

But with Qiu Zimin dying like this, it made it seem like she had done something wrong.

Shen Yaobo comforted her for a while, and the Shen family members also took turns trying to console her. But Zhu Mingqi still remained bedridden, showing signs of falling ill.

Everyone had no choice but to go find Liang Shi.

After Liang Shi entered her room, she thought for a moment and asked: "Would you like to go shopping with me?"

Zhu Mingqi: "?!"

Zhu Mingqi was instantly revived to full health.

When they went shopping, they were buying baby supplies. Every time they passed by such stores, Zhu Mingqi would mention things from when Liang Shi was little.

They had clearly only known each other for about a month, but Zhu Mingqi had so many things to talk about.

How happy Zhu Mingqi had been when she was pregnant with Liang Shi—and how depressed she became after Liang Shi "passed away."

Zhu Mingqi said she had originally wanted to name her Shen Xuanyan.

Bright and beautiful like the sun.

Later, she named her fourth child Shen Siyan—"Si" meaning "to miss," missing Shen Xuanyan.

Shen Siyan's name contained her within it.

Every time this was mentioned to Shen Siyan, she would eat an extra half bowl of rice, saying she was living well on behalf of her sister.

Even though Liang Shi had already heard about this, hearing it again from Zhu Mingqi still moved her.

However...

"The name I didn't get to use—let's give it to my children." Liang Shi said. "One character each, just enough to share."

Zhu Mingqi asked about Xu Qingzhu's due date and decided to clear her schedule to take good care of Xu Qingzhu.

Without Liang Shi knowing, Zhu Mingqi had already become good friends with Su Yao and Sheng Linlang.

When Liang Shi had seen Sheng Linlang before, she had looked somewhat pale and melancholic, but recently she was obviously much better.

Liang Wanwan, who had returned from abroad to attend Qiu Zimin's funeral, also met with Liang Shi.

Liang Shi expressed her regret over Qiu Zimin's passing.

But Liang Wanwan said: "Her illness was discovered a long time ago, but she wouldn't let anyone say anything and just kept pushing through. Jie, she treated you badly all these years, but she's dead now. Consider it her atonement. Don't hate her anymore, and don't let yourself be angry."

Liang Shi naturally couldn't say anything more and just comforted her with a few words.

Qiu Zimin's funeral was kept simple.

Liang Shi also went to offer a flower and bowed.

It could be considered the dust finally settling.

Footnotes:

¹ "Fury attacked her heart" (急火攻心, jí huǒ gōng xīn) - A traditional Chinese medicine concept where extreme emotional distress, particularly anger or anxiety, causes internal damage to the body. It's believed that such intense emotions can disrupt the body's qi (vital energy) and affect the heart, potentially causing physical symptoms like vomiting blood or collapse.